

4.1 Getting Around In Windows XP

In order to help users be at ease with the new look and interface, Windows XP offers a tour that tells you about the operating system in general. This tour starts by default upon completion of the installation. You can also run the tour at any time by clicking Start > All Programs > Accessories > Tour Windows XP. Here, we take you on a slightly different tour of the OS, with the idea being the same—getting you familiar with XP.

4.1.1 The Taskbar And Start Menu

The default XP desktop scheme is a bright blue with a landscape wallpaper. At the bottom of your screen is the Taskbar with the Start button (as in Windows 98). All the programs and installed applications are accessible from the Start button, while the Taskbar holds buttons corresponding to running applications. The right-hand corner of the Taskbar is known as the System Tray. It displays the clock (Date/Time settings) and volume/sound controls by default, and any application that has been enabled to start with Windows XP will appear in the System Tray. The System Tray also displays network connectivity if this is enabled in Network Connections. In short, the Taskbar and the Start Menu gives you quick access to various applications and system utilities.

Assume you have many Internet Explorer windows open at the same time. These sessions (or open browsers) are grouped within a single taskbar button. Clicking the button will list all the open windows. This happens because the option to ‘Group similar taskbar buttons’ is enabled by default. This behaviour of the Taskbar can be controlled and altered by changing its properties. To modify the properties of the Taskbar, right-click on an empty space on it and choose ‘Properties’. The window that opens allows you to view and change the properties of both the Taskbar and the Start Menu.

Here’s a screenshot of the pop-up window called ‘Taskbar and Start Menu Properties’. There are two tabs under this menu—one for the Taskbar and one for the Start Menu. The Taskbar tab is divided